

Communication Skills

Course: CPA — Certified Public Accountant

Level: Foundation Level (CA12)

Last updated: 29 July 2026

Syllabus version: Based on the standard KASNEB CPA Foundation Level Communication Skills syllabus topics (CA12) — the communication process, business writing, oral communication, and meetings. Authored from general business-communication knowledge and standard syllabus topic coverage, not copied from any existing notes provider or study guide. Cross-check terminology and emphasis against the current KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports before the exam.

Original work notice. Every explanation, worked example, and question in this document was written from scratch for this paper. No text has been copied or paraphrased from any KASNEB past paper, textbook, or third-party notes/study guide. The scenarios and practice questions are original.

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1. The communication process and its purpose

Communication is the process of transmitting a message from a sender to a receiver, with the intention of it being understood as intended. The basic process: sender → encodes a message → transmits it through a chosen channel → receiver decodes the message → feedback returns to the sender confirming (or not) that the message was understood correctly. In business, communication serves several purposes: informing, instructing, persuading, motivating and building relationships between an organisation and its various stakeholders (staff, customers, suppliers, regulators, the public).

2. Barriers to effective communication

- **Physical barriers** — noise, distance, poor-quality equipment or connections.
- **Language barriers** — jargon, technical terms, or genuine language differences between sender and receiver.
- **Perceptual/psychological barriers** — differing assumptions, biases, or emotional states that distort how a message is interpreted.
- **Organisational barriers** — overly long or unclear reporting lines, information overload, or a rigid hierarchy that discourages upward feedback.
- **Cultural barriers** — differing norms and expectations across cultures, particularly relevant for organisations operating internationally or across diverse teams.

Overcoming these barriers requires clarity of language, appropriate channel choice, active listening, and deliberately inviting and using feedback to confirm understanding.

3. Verbal, non-verbal and written communication

- **Verbal communication** — spoken, face-to-face or by telephone/video call — allows immediate feedback and clarification.
- **Non-verbal communication** — body language, facial expression, tone of voice, posture — often communicates as much as, or more than, the words themselves in face-to-face settings.
- **Written communication** — letters, memos, reports, emails — provides a permanent, referenceable record, though feedback is slower and tone can be more easily misread.

Effective communicators consciously match the channel to the message: routine internal instructions might suit a memo or email; a sensitive personnel matter is usually better handled verbally, with any written record following afterward to confirm what was agreed.

4. Business letters and memoranda

A **business letter** is a formal written communication, typically used for external correspondence (with customers, suppliers, regulators), following a conventional structure: sender's address, date, recipient's address, salutation, body, complimentary close, and signature. A **memorandum (memo)** is a shorter, typically internal communication for routine matters, usually following a simple header format (To / From / Date / Subject) followed by a concise message body — no salutation or complimentary close required.

5. Report writing

A **business report** is a structured document presenting information, analysis and (often) recommendations on a specific matter. A typical structure includes: a **title**, **terms of reference** (why the report was commissioned and by whom), **procedure** (how the information was gathered), **findings**, and **conclusions/recommendations**. Good reports are objective, evidence-based, clearly structured with headings, and written in language appropriate to the intended reader.

6. Oral communication and presentations

Effective oral communication and presentations require: clear structure (an introduction stating the purpose, a body covering the main points logically, and a conclusion summarising key takeaways), appropriate pace and tone, audience awareness (pitching content and language to what the specific audience already knows and needs), and confident, practised delivery. Visual aids (slides, charts) should support — not replace — the spoken content, and should be simple enough not to distract from the speaker's message.

7. Meetings — types, roles and documentation

Common meeting types include **formal statutory meetings** (e.g. an annual general meeting, governed by specific legal/procedural requirements) and **informal working meetings** (department or project meetings, more flexible in format). Key meeting roles: the **chairperson** (leads the meeting, ensures order and that the agenda is followed) and the **secretary** (prepares the agenda, records minutes, and circulates them afterward). A **quorum** is the minimum number of members required to be present for a meeting's business to be validly conducted. **Minutes** are the official written record of what was discussed and decided, including any resolutions passed and actions assigned.

8. Communication technology in business

Modern business communication increasingly relies on: email (fast, written, provides a permanent record), video conferencing (enables real-time discussion across distant locations, combining some benefits of face-to-face communication with reduced travel cost), instant messaging/collaboration platforms (fast, informal, useful for quick internal coordination), and intranets/shared drives (centralising internal documents and announcements). Each channel suits different message types — routine quick coordination suits instant messaging; a formal decision affecting many stakeholders is usually better documented in a structured email or report.

9. Full worked question — drafting a short business memo

Scenario. The finance manager needs to inform all department heads that the deadline for submitting next year's budget proposals has moved from 30 November to 15 November, due to an earlier board review date.

Required: Draft a short memo communicating this change.

Solution:

MEMORANDUM

To: All Department Heads

From: Finance Manager

Date: [current date]

Subject: Revised Deadline for Budget Proposal Submissions

Please note that the deadline for submitting your department's budget proposals for next year has been moved forward, from 30 November to **15 November**. This change is necessary to accommodate an earlier board review date.

Kindly ensure your proposals are finalised and submitted to the Finance Office by the new deadline. Please contact the Finance Office if you anticipate any difficulty meeting this revised date.

10. Practice examination — KASNEB-style paper (original, not a past paper)

Note on format. This section is laid out the way a KASNEB CPA examination paper is laid out — a timed paper with five compulsory 20-mark questions — purely so you can practise under realistic exam

conditions. Every question below is an original scenario written for this document. **It is not a reproduction of any actual KASNEB past examination paper.**

CPA FOUNDATION LEVEL — COMMUNICATION SKILLS (PRACTICE PAPER)

TIME ALLOWED: 3 HOURS

Instructions to candidates: Answer ALL FIVE questions. Each question carries 20 marks. Show all workings clearly.

QUESTION ONE

- (a) Describe the communication process, from sender to feedback. *(8 marks)*
 - (b) Outline FOUR barriers to effective communication. *(8 marks)*
 - (c) Suggest ONE way to overcome each of TWO barriers you have identified. *(4 marks)*
- (Total: 20 marks)*
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QUESTION TWO

- (a) Distinguish between verbal, non-verbal, and written communication, with one example of each. *(12 marks)*
 - (b) Advise a manager on which channel would be most appropriate for communicating a sensitive personnel matter, with reasons. *(8 marks)*
- (Total: 20 marks)*
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QUESTION THREE

- (a) Distinguish between a business letter and a memorandum in terms of purpose and structure. *(10 marks)*
 - (b) Outline the typical structure of a business report. *(10 marks)*
- (Total: 20 marks)*
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QUESTION FOUR

- (a) Outline FOUR qualities of an effective oral presentation. *(12 marks)*
 - (b) Explain the role of visual aids in a presentation, and ONE risk of over-relying on them. *(8 marks)*
- (Total: 20 marks)*
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QUESTION FIVE

- (a) Distinguish between the roles of a chairperson and a secretary in a meeting. *(8 marks)*
 - (b) Define "quorum" and explain its significance for a meeting's validity. *(6 marks)*
 - (c) Explain the purpose of minutes, and outline TWO items they typically record. *(6 marks)*
- (Total: 20 marks)*
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11. Marking guide — model answers to the practice examination**QUESTION ONE**

- (a) *(8 marks)* — Sender encodes a message → transmits through a chosen channel → receiver decodes it → feedback returns to the sender, confirming whether it was understood as intended.
- (b) *(8 marks — 2 marks each)* — Physical, language, perceptual/psychological, organisational (or cultural).
- (c) *(4 marks — 2 marks each)* — E.g. language barrier: use plain language and avoid jargon; organisational barrier: shorten reporting lines or actively invite upward feedback.

QUESTION TWO

- (a) *(12 marks — 4 marks each)* — Verbal: spoken, e.g. a phone call — allows immediate feedback. Non-verbal: e.g. body language/tone — often communicates as much as the words. Written: e.g. an email/report — provides a permanent record.
- (b) *(8 marks)* — Verbal communication (in person) is generally most appropriate for a sensitive personnel matter, since it allows tone, empathy and immediate clarification, with a brief written record following afterward to confirm what was discussed/agreed.

QUESTION THREE

- (a) *(10 marks)* — A business letter is typically formal, used for external correspondence, with a full structure (addresses, salutation, complimentary close); a memo is shorter, typically internal, for routine matters, using a simple header format without salutation/complimentary close.
- (b) *(10 marks — 2 marks each)* — Title, terms of reference, procedure, findings, conclusions/recommendations.

QUESTION FOUR

- (a) *(12 marks — 3 marks each)* — Clear structure (introduction/body/conclusion), appropriate pace and tone, audience awareness, confident/practised delivery.

(b) (8 marks) — Visual aids support and reinforce the spoken message (e.g. illustrating data or key points); a risk of over-reliance is that overly detailed or numerous slides can distract from, rather than support, the speaker's actual message.

QUESTION FIVE

(a) (8 marks) — The chairperson leads the meeting, ensures order and that the agenda is followed; the secretary prepares the agenda, records minutes, and circulates them afterward.

(b) (6 marks) — A quorum is the minimum number of members required to be present for a meeting's business to be validly conducted; without it, decisions taken may not be legally/procedurally valid.

(c) (6 marks) — Minutes provide the official record of what was discussed and decided; they typically record resolutions passed and actions assigned (attendance and apologies also acceptable).

12. Exam technique and revision checklist

- Always describe the communication process as an ordered flow (sender → encode → channel → receiver → decode → feedback), not just a list of unrelated terms.
- Barrier questions: pair each named barrier with a brief explanation of *why* it disrupts communication, and be ready to suggest a specific remedy if asked.
- "Distinguish" questions (letter vs memo, verbal vs written): use the same criteria on both sides of the comparison for a clear, structured contrast.
- Meeting questions: know the specific roles (chairperson, secretary) and terms (quorum, minutes, resolution) precisely — these are commonly and specifically tested.
- Report-writing questions: know the standard structure by name and in the correct order, not just a vague sense of "what a report includes."

Quick revision — one line per topic:

1. Communication process: sender → encode → channel → receiver → decode → feedback.
2. Barriers: physical, language, perceptual/psychological, organisational, cultural.
3. Verbal (immediate feedback) vs written (permanent record) vs non-verbal (often carries as much meaning as words).
4. Business letter: formal, external, full structure. Memo: short, internal, simple header.
5. Report structure: title, terms of reference, procedure, findings, conclusions/recommendations.
6. Effective oral presentation: clear structure, appropriate pace/tone, audience awareness, confident delivery.

7. Meeting roles: chairperson (leads/order), secretary (agenda/minutes). Quorum = minimum attendance for validity.
8. Communication technology: email, video conferencing, instant messaging, intranets — match channel to message.

End of study notes. This document is intended as original exam-preparation material and should be used alongside the current official KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports for the paper.